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ELECTRONIC TRAVEL AUTHORISATION (UK ETA)



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ELECTRONIC TRAVEL AUTHORISATION (UK ETA)

The UK Electronic Travel Authorisation (ETA) is a pre-travel screening requirement introduced as part of the UK Government's wider digital transformation of border controls. The ETA scheme applies to visa-exempt travellers—also known as non-visa nationals—who wish to enter the United Kingdom for short-term visits or under limited work-related concessions.

Under this scheme, eligible travellers must obtain authorisation in advance of their journey. The UK ETA is not a visa, but a mandatory pre-approval linked electronically to the traveller's passport, allowing multiple short visits to the UK for up to two years or until the expiry of the passport, whichever comes sooner.

The Electronic Travel Authorisation system represents a significant shift in UK immigration policy, bringing the UK in line with similar international models such as the US ESTA and the forthcoming EU ETIAS. Its introduction enhances the UK's ability to conduct security checks on travellers before they depart for the UK, enabling immigration authorities to identify risks earlier in the process and deny boarding where necessary.

ETA Refused? This doesn't mean you can't travel to the UK – but it does mean that you'll probably need to apply for a visa instead. At Richmond Chambers, our immigration barristers can assess your situation, advise on your next steps, and prepare a strong visa application on your behalf.

What Is the UK Electronic Travel Authorisation (ETA)?

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The UK Electronic Travel Authorisation (ETA) is a digital pre-clearance requirement for non-visa nationals seeking to travel to the United Kingdom as a **Visitor** (<https://immigrationbarrister.co.uk/personal-immigration/short-stay-visit-visas/>) or under the **Creative Worker visa concession** (<https://immigrationbarrister.co.uk/personal-immigration/short-term-work-visas/temporary-work-creative-worker-visa/>). It is designed to strengthen border security and modernise the UK's immigration control system by ensuring that individuals who are not required to obtain a visa are nonetheless subject to security and suitability checks before departure.

Key Features of the UK ETA

- **Not a visa:** The ETA is not a visa and does not grant leave to enter the UK. Instead, it is a pre-travel authorisation that allows eligible travellers to board a flight, ferry, or train to the UK. Final permission to enter is still granted by an immigration officer upon arrival.
- **Mandatory for non-visa nationals:** The ETA is required for individuals from countries that do not normally require a visa for short visits to the UK (i.e. for tourism, business, study of up to six months, or for limited work purposes under the Creative Worker visa concession).
- **Electronically linked to a passport:** Once approved, the ETA is digitally linked to the passport used in the application. It is valid for up to two years, or until the passport expires—whichever comes first.
- **Multiple entries permitted:** Travellers can use a valid ETA for multiple visits to the UK, provided each visit complies with the terms of the Visitor route or Creative Worker concession.

Who Needs a UK ETA?

The requirement to obtain a UK Electronic Travel Authorisation (ETA) applies to *non-visa nationals*—that is, nationals of countries who do not ordinarily need a visa to visit the UK for short stays. The ETA must be obtained before travel and applies regardless of whether the traveller is visiting for tourism, business, study (for up to six months), transit, or permitted creative work (for up to three months under the Creative Worker concession).

The ETA does not apply to visa nationals (i.e. those who are already required to apply for a visit visa before travelling to the UK), nor to individuals who hold an alternative form of UK immigration status such as a visa, settled status, British or Irish citizenship.

Nationals Who Require a UK ETA

The UK Electronic Travel Authorisation (ETA) scheme applies to all non-visa nationals travelling to the United Kingdom. Individuals who were previously permitted to enter the UK without a visa for short stays must now obtain an ETA before travelling as a visitor

(other than as a Marriage or Civil Partnership Visitor), under the Creative Worker visa concession, or when transiting through the UK.

(<https://www.google.co.uk>

(/) The ETA requirement now applies to nationals from the Middle East, including Bahrain, Kuwait, Oman, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, and the United Arab Emirates.

Across Europe, the requirement extends to all nationals of European Union Member States, including Austria, Belgium, Bulgaria, Croatia, Cyprus, Czechia, Denmark, Estonia, Finland, France, Germany, Greece, Hungary, Ireland, Italy, Latvia, Lithuania, Luxembourg, Malta, the Netherlands, Poland, Portugal, Romania, Slovakia, Slovenia, Spain, and Sweden. It also includes nationals of the European Economic Area (Iceland, Liechtenstein, and Norway), as well as other European states and microstates such as Andorra, Monaco, San Marino, Switzerland, and Vatican City.

Irish citizens continue to be exempt from the ETA requirement. In addition, non-visa nationals who are legally resident in Ireland and entering the UK via the land border into Northern Ireland are not required to obtain an ETA. However, travellers who are not Irish citizens and are entering the UK from outside the Common Travel Area must apply for one.

In the Americas, the ETA is now required for nationals of Antigua and Barbuda, Argentina, Barbados, Belize, Brazil, Canada, Chile, Colombia, Costa Rica, Grenada, Guatemala, Guyana, Mexico, Nicaragua, Panama, Paraguay, Peru, Saint Kitts and Nevis, Saint Lucia, Saint Vincent and the Grenadines, Trinidad and Tobago, the United States, and Uruguay.

From the Asia-Pacific region, the requirement covers travellers from Australia, Brunei, Hong Kong SAR (including British Nationals (Overseas)), Israel, Japan, Kiribati, Macao SAR, Malaysia, Maldives, the Marshall Islands, Micronesia, Nauru, New Zealand, Palau, Papua New Guinea, Samoa, Seychelles, Singapore, Solomon Islands, South Korea, Taiwan (where the passport includes the holder's Taiwanese national ID number), Tonga, and Tuvalu.

In Africa, the ETA requirement currently applies to nationals of Botswana and Mauritius.

If your nationality is not listed above, you are considered a visa national and must apply for a visa to enter the United Kingdom, regardless of the duration or purpose of your stay.

Who Does Not Need an ETA?

You do not need an Electronic Travel Authorisation if:

- You are a visa national and must already apply for a UK visit visa before travel.
- You are a British citizen, Irish citizen, or a holder of another form of UK immigration status (e.g. Indefinite Leave to Remain, pre-settled or settled status under the EU Settlement Scheme, a UK visa).
- You are legally resident in Ireland and entering the UK over the land border from the Republic of Ireland into Northern Ireland (subject to specific exemptions).

If your country of nationality does not appear in the lists above, you must continue to apply for a visa to visit the UK. You are not eligible for a UK ETA. [. \(https://www.google.co.uk/search?q=richmond+chambers+immigration+barristers\)](https://www.google.co.uk/search?q=richmond+chambers+immigration+barristers)

When Should You Apply for an ETA?

The timing of your UK ETA application is critical to ensuring smooth travel. You must apply for and obtain a valid UK Electronic Travel Authorisation *before* boarding a flight, ferry, or train bound for the United Kingdom. If you attempt to travel without an ETA when one is required, you will be refused boarding.

While most ETA applications are processed within three working days, travellers are advised to apply well in advance of their intended departure date to allow time for:

- Any delays in Home Office processing;
- Requests for additional information;
- The possibility of a refusal and the need to apply for a visa instead.

You may submit your ETA application at any time prior to travel. There is no need to wait until close to your departure date.

Travel Without a Valid ETA

Travellers who are required to hold an ETA and attempt to board a plane, train or ferry to the UK without one will be denied boarding by the transport carrier. Carriers are legally obligated to check ETA status before allowing embarkation. Arrival at the UK border without a valid ETA may also result in refusal of entry.

In short, if you are a non-visa national and your travel date falls after the relevant implementation date for your nationality, you must not travel without first securing a valid UK ETA.

What Can You Do with a UK ETA?

A UK Electronic Travel Authorisation (ETA) permits eligible non-visa nationals to travel to the United Kingdom for short stays without first obtaining a visa. While an ETA is not a visa and does not grant entry in itself, it enables travellers to board a flight, ferry, or train to the UK and seek entry on arrival. Subject to border checks, ETA holders may undertake a variety of permitted activities in line with the UK's **Visitor immigration rules** (<https://immigrationbarrister.co.uk/personal-immigration/short-stay-visit-visas/>) or the Creative Worker visa concession.

Permitted Activities Under a UK ETA

With a valid ETA, travellers may visit the UK for up to six months at a time to engage in the following types of activity:

- Tourism and leisure travel
- Visiting friends or family (<https://www.google.co.uk>)
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- (7) Business-related activities (e.g. attending meetings, conferences, or interviews)
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- Short-term study (up to six months at an accredited institution)
- Medical treatment (private care, subject to evidence and compliance with rules)

Additionally, ETA holders may undertake certain work-related activities, where permitted under the Immigration Rules for Visitors. For example:

- Attending trade fairs, giving talks or speeches (without payment)
- Performing in certain permitted creative roles, such as artists, entertainers or musicians, subject to conditions

Temporary Work – Creative Worker Concession

One of the notable features of the ETA scheme is that it also applies to those entering under the **Temporary Work – Creative Worker visa concession** (<https://immigrationbarrister.co.uk/personal-immigration/short-term-work-visas/temporary-work-creative-worker-visa/>). This route permits non-visa nationals to undertake short-term creative assignments in the UK without a full visa, provided the assignment is for a maximum of three months, meets the requirements of the Creative Worker route and is supported by a UK sponsor.

Individuals using the ETA to enter under this concession must not exceed the three-month limit, and their work must be limited to activities permitted under this specific visa exemption.

Validity and Reusability of a UK Electronic Travel Authorisation

A UK Electronic Travel Authorisation is valid for a period of two years from the date of issue, or until the expiry of the passport used in the application—whichever occurs first. During this time, it permits multiple entries into the United Kingdom, provided that each visit complies with the conditions set out in the UK's immigration rules.

However, it is important to understand the limitations of the UK ETA. It does not grant the right to work in the UK outside the narrowly defined activities permitted under the Visitor route or the Creative Worker concession. Nor does it confer permission to settle in the UK, access public funds, or undertake long-term study. Individuals intending to carry out any activities beyond those allowed under the ETA scheme must instead apply for an appropriate UK visa.

How to Apply for a UK Electronic Travel Authorisation (ETA)

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Applying for a UK ETA is a fully digital process that can be completed online via a dedicated mobile application. The process is intended to be straightforward for the majority of applicants, but it is essential to ensure accuracy and completeness to avoid delays or refusal.

Application Methods for a UK Electronic Travel Authorisation

You can apply for a UK ETA using either of the following methods:

- The official UK ETA mobile app (available for download via iOS and Android)
- The UK Government's official online ETA application form

The method chosen does not affect processing or outcome, but the mobile app may allow for easier upload of documents and tracking.

What You'll Need to Apply for a UK ETA

When submitting your application for an Electronic Travel Authorisation, you will be required to provide:

- A valid national passport
- A digital passport-style photograph
- Personal details, including your name, date of birth, and contact information
- Travel details, if known
- Suitability and security-related information, including:
 - Criminal history
 - Previous immigration history
 - Any health or public conduct concerns

It is mandatory to use a national passport for the ETA application. Travel documents such as refugee travel documents or national identity cards are not accepted for this purpose. If you do not hold a valid national passport, you will need to apply for a UK visa instead.

ETA Application Fee

As of April 2025, the cost to apply for an Electronic Travel Authorisation is:

- £16 per applicant

The application fee must be paid online at the time of submission, using a valid debit or credit card. The fee is non-refundable, even if the application is refused.

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Each individual traveller must hold their own ETA, including children and infants. Parents or guardians can complete ETA applications on behalf of minors, but a separate application and fee is required for each person.

Although the UK ETA application process is relatively simple, applicants must satisfy a set of suitability criteria set out in the UK Immigration Rules. Failure to meet these criteria will result in a refusal. In certain cases, a previously granted ETA may also be cancelled if new information comes to light.

The suitability criteria are designed to ensure that individuals who may pose a risk to public safety, have a history of immigration abuse, or have engaged in deception or criminal activity do not enter the UK through the streamlined ETA system.

An application for an Electronic Travel Authorisation *must* be refused if any of the following apply:

- **Exclusion or Deportation Orders**
 - You are the subject of a deportation order or exclusion direction issued by the Home Secretary.
 - You are currently excluded from the UK for national security or public policy reasons.
- **Criminality**
 - You have been convicted of a criminal offence for which you received a custodial sentence of 12 months or more.
 - You have any criminal conviction (UK or overseas) unless 12 months have passed since the date of conviction.
- **Non-Conductive Conduct**
 - Your presence in the UK is deemed not conducive to the public good, based on your conduct, character, associations, or other relevant factors—even if you have no convictions.
- **Previous Breaches of UK Immigration Laws**
 - You previously overstayed your leave, breached a visa condition, or used deception in an immigration application.

- Even if you were later granted new leave or permission, a breach may still result in ETA refusal unless explicitly overlooked by the Home Office. (<https://www.google.co.uk/search?q=richmond+chambers+immigration+barristers>)
- You submitted false documents or misleading information in relation to your ETA or any prior UK immigration application.
 - Omission of relevant facts can also be grounds for refusal, regardless of your intent.
 - **Unpaid NHS Debt**
 - You owe £500 or more in charges for treatment received from the NHS as an overseas visitor.
 - **Unpaid Litigation Costs**
 - You have failed to pay costs awarded to the Home Office in connection with previous legal proceedings.

Expanded Suitability Criteria: Key Changes Introduced in 2024

Following the Statement of Changes to the Immigration Rules (HC 217), published on 10 September 2024, the following additional refusal criteria now apply:

- **Overstayers:** Individuals who have previously overstayed their visa in the UK may now be refused an ETA even if they left voluntarily. The rules now mirror the visitor visa suitability test, taking into account duration and circumstances of the overstay.
- **Previous Visa Refusals:** If you were previously refused a UK visit visa or refused entry as a visitor, your ETA will be refused—unless you were subsequently granted a visit visa or other valid UK immigration status.
- **Cancelled ETAs:** If your previous ETA was cancelled for *any reason*, including administrative or procedural grounds, a new ETA application will also be refused. You must instead apply for a visa.

Importance of Full Disclosure

When completing your ETA application, you should answer all questions honestly and disclose all relevant information. Even seemingly minor omissions or historic matters may trigger refusal. If in doubt, we recommend seeking legal advice before submitting your application.

What If Your UK ETA Application Is Refused?

A refusal of a UK Electronic Travel Authorisation (ETA) can be unsettling, particularly for those who have previously travelled to the UK without issue. However, a refused ETA does not amount to a refusal of permission to enter the United Kingdom. It simply means that you cannot travel to the UK under the ETA scheme and must instead apply for a relevant UK visa.

Understanding the implications of a refusal—and your options—is key to continuing with your UK travel plans lawfully and without unnecessary delay.

What Does a UK ETA Refusal Mean?

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If your ETA application is refused:

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- You will not be permitted to board a plane, ferry, or train to the UK;
- You will not be allowed to travel to the UK under visa-free arrangements;
- You are not banned from entering the UK;
- You may still be eligible to apply for a UK visa, which provides a formal route for pre-entry clearance.

Visa Options Following ETA Refusal

Depending on the purpose of your intended visit, you may be able to apply for one of the following visas:

- **Standard Visitor Visa** – for tourism, family visits, business meetings, short-term study (up to 6 months), or private medical treatment;
- **Temporary Work – Creative Worker Visa** – for eligible creative professionals undertaking short-term paid work engagements;

A visa application will require more detailed supporting documentation, biometric enrolment, and a more thorough assessment of your immigration history and background.

Common Reasons for Refusal of a UK ETA

ETA applications may be refused for a variety of reasons, including:

- Past criminal convictions or non-conductive behaviour;
- Overstaying or breaching immigration rules during a previous visit;
- Submission of false documents or misleading information;
- Outstanding NHS debts or unpaid legal costs;
- Having had a previous UK visa or ETA cancelled or refused.

Even a minor error or omission on your ETA application can lead to refusal.

Can I Reapply for an ETA?

In some cases, yes—if your application was refused due to incomplete or incorrect information, and you can now address the issue with an accurate and updated application. However, if the refusal was based on a substantive suitability concern (e.g. criminality, immigration breaches), it is unlikely that a fresh ETA will be approved unless circumstances have changed.

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Consequences of an ETA Cancellation

Once an ETA is cancelled:

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- The traveller will no longer be permitted to use the ETA for UK entry;
- They may be denied boarding by the airline, ferry, or train operator;
- If they arrive at the UK border, they may be refused entry;
- Any future application for an ETA will be refused automatically, regardless of whether the cancellation was for suitability or technical reasons.

Visa Application Following Cancellation

If your ETA has been cancelled, you must apply for a UK visa appropriate to the nature of your visit. This could be a:

- Standard Visitor Visa;
- Creative Worker Visa (under the Temporary Work route);

Visa applications following cancellation of an ETA are likely to be subject to greater scrutiny, and applicants will need to explain the circumstances surrounding the cancellation in full.

Legal Advice Following ETA Cancellation

Given the serious implications of ETA cancellation, it is advisable to seek specialist immigration legal advice before taking further steps. A carefully prepared visa application may still succeed, but only if the issues giving rise to the cancellation are properly addressed.

Our immigration barristers at Richmond Chambers regularly assist individuals who have had an ETA cancelled and can provide strategic advice tailored to your situation.

How Long Is a UK ETA Valid For?

Once granted, a UK Electronic Travel Authorisation (ETA) provides non-visa nationals with the flexibility to travel to the United Kingdom multiple times over a set period. Understanding the validity and conditions of use is essential for planning travel and ensuring compliance with UK immigration rules.

Validity Period of the UK ETA

A UK ETA is generally valid for the earliest of:

- Two years from the date of grant, or
- Until the passport used in the application expires

If your passport is due to expire within two years of your ETA being granted, the ETA will expire on the same date as your passport. You cannot transfer an existing ETA to a new passport; instead, you must apply for a new ETA once you obtain a replacement passport.

Multiple Entry Authorisation

A valid ETA permits multiple entries into the United Kingdom during its validity period. You may enter and leave the UK as many times as you wish, provided that:

- Each visit complies with the permitted activities under the Visitor Rules or Creative Worker concession; and
- You do not overstay the permitted duration of your stay (usually up to six months as a visitor, or three months as a Creative Worker under the concession).

Permitted Length of Stay Per Visit

- **Visitor route:** You may stay in the UK for up to six months per visit, for tourism, business, study, or other permitted visitor activities.
- **Creative Worker concession:** You may stay for up to three months per engagement, provided the visit meets all conditions under the Creative Worker route.

Each stay must be temporary in nature. The ETA does not entitle you to live, work (outside permitted activities), or study long-term in the UK.

Does an ETA Guarantee Entry to the UK?

No. Holding an ETA allows you to travel to the UK, but final permission to enter is granted by a Border Force officer upon arrival. If there are concerns at the border—such as doubts about your intentions or compliance with immigration rules—you may still be refused entry despite holding a valid ETA.

UK ETA and Travel from Ireland or the Common Travel Area

The United Kingdom and the Republic of Ireland share a unique arrangement known as the Common Travel Area (CTA). This includes the UK, Ireland, the Isle of Man, and the Channel Islands. As a result, special rules apply to travel across the land border between Ireland and Northern Ireland, particularly in relation to the UK Electronic Travel Authorisation (ETA) scheme.

Do I Need a UK ETA if I'm Travelling from Ireland to Northern Ireland?

Whether you need a UK ETA when crossing the Irish border depends on your residency status in Ireland:

- If you are a non-visa national who is legally resident in Ireland, you do not need an ETA to cross into Northern Ireland by land.
- (7) If you are a visitor in Ireland, or you are not resident in Ireland and you travel from outside the Common Travel Area, then you must obtain a UK ETA before travelling to any part of the UK, including Northern Ireland.

In short, the land border between the Republic of Ireland and Northern Ireland is not subject to routine immigration checks, but the legal requirement to hold an ETA may still apply depending on your circumstances.

Travelling to the UK by Air or Sea from Ireland

If you are flying or taking a ferry to England, Scotland, Wales, or Northern Ireland from outside the Common Travel Area, and you are a non-visa national, then you must apply for and obtain an ETA before your journey.

This includes:

- Travellers who are transiting through Ireland en route to the UK;
- Travellers who are not legally resident in Ireland.

Irish Citizens and the ETA Scheme

Irish citizens are not subject to the ETA requirement. This exemption is grounded in the UK's longstanding commitment to free movement for Irish nationals within the Common Travel Area. Irish citizens may continue to enter, live and work in the UK without needing a visa or ETA.

It is essential to assess your own residency and travel circumstances carefully. If you are unsure whether the UK ETA requirement applies to you, you may wish to seek legal advice before travelling.

Difference Between the UK ETA and EU ETIAS

As countries continue to modernise border security and immigration systems, two key electronic travel authorisation schemes have emerged in Europe: the United Kingdom's Electronic Travel Authorisation (ETA) and the European Union's forthcoming European Travel Information and Authorisation System (ETIAS).

While both systems share the objective of screening visa-exempt travellers before departure, they differ significantly in their geographic scope, implementation timelines, permitted travel conditions, and application procedures. A clear understanding of these differences is essential for international travellers navigating either UK or EU entry requirements.

Overview of the UK ETA

The UK ETA was introduced by the UK Government as a pre-travel authorisation for non-visa nationals seeking to visit the United Kingdom. It applies to individuals travelling for short-term purposes, including tourism, business, short study, medical treatment, or transit. The ETA also accommodates visits under the Creative Worker visa concession, which permits short-term paid creative engagements for up to three months.

ETA authorisation is valid for two years, or until the applicant's passport expires, whichever comes first. During this period, the holder may make multiple visits to the UK, provided each stay complies with the relevant immigration rules. Applications are submitted either via the official UK ETA mobile app or through an online portal. The phased rollout of the scheme began in 2023 and was completed for EU, EEA and Swiss nationals on 2 April 2025.

Overview of the EU ETIAS

The EU's ETIAS, expected to launch in late 2026, will apply to nationals of around 60 visa-exempt countries, including the United Kingdom, United States, Canada, Australia, and Japan. Travellers who currently enjoy visa-free access to Europe will be required to obtain ETIAS authorisation prior to travelling to any of the 30 participating European countries, which include all Schengen Area states as well as Bulgaria, Romania, and Cyprus.

An approved ETIAS will be valid for three years, or until the traveller's passport expires, and will allow multiple short stays of up to 90 days in any 180-day period. Applications will be made through an official EU-managed platform, with most decisions expected to be issued automatically within minutes of submission.

Key Similarities and Distinctions

Both the UK ETA and EU ETIAS are mandatory for eligible travellers prior to boarding any flight, ferry, or train bound for their respective destinations. Each system involves automated checks against national and international security and immigration databases. Importantly, neither the ETA nor ETIAS constitutes a visa, and neither guarantees entry; final decisions remain at the discretion of border control authorities.

Both schemes are multi-entry authorisations, enabling multiple trips during the period of validity. However, the ETA permits longer stays per visit—up to six months under the UK Visitor Rules—whereas ETIAS restricts each stay to no more than 90 days within any 180-day rolling window.

Which Travel Authorisation Do You Need?

If you are travelling to the United Kingdom as a non-visa national, you will need to obtain a UK ETA before departure. Conversely, if you are visiting European countries participating in ETIAS from a visa-exempt country, you will need to apply for ETIAS once the system becomes operational.

It is important to note that British citizens will be subject to the ETAs requirement for travel to Europe following its implementation in 2026.

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Frequently Asked Questions About the UK ETA

The UK Electronic Travel Authorisation (ETA) scheme is a relatively new requirement, and many travellers have questions about how it works, who it applies to, and how to remain compliant. Below, we answer some of the most frequently asked questions about the UK ETA.

1. Is the ETA a visa?

No. The ETA is not a visa. It is a digital pre-travel authorisation that permits eligible non-visa nationals to travel to the UK for short stays. It does not grant leave to enter the UK, which is still subject to border control on arrival.

2. Do I need an ETA if I already have a UK visa or immigration status?

No. If you hold a valid UK visa, settled or pre-settled status under the EU Settlement Scheme, or another form of UK immigration permission, you do not need an ETA.

3. Do children need an ETA?

Yes. All travellers, including infants and children, must hold a valid ETA before travelling to the UK. Parents or guardians may complete the application on their behalf.

4. Can I use an ID card instead of a passport to apply?

No. ETA applications must be submitted using a national passport. ID cards, refugee travel documents, or other forms of identification are not accepted. Individuals travelling on such documents must apply for a UK visa instead.

5. How much does a UK ETA cost?

As of April 2025, the application fee for a UK ETA is £16 per person. The fee is payable online during the application process.

6. How long is the ETA valid for?

An ETA is valid for two years, or until the expiry of the passport used in the application—whichever comes first. It allows for multiple entries during its validity, subject to compliance with visitor rules.

7. How long can I stay in the UK with an ETA?

You may stay for up to:

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- Six months under the UK Visitor Rules;
- Three months if using the ETA to enter under the Creative Worker concession.

Each visit must be temporary and meet the permitted activity criteria.

8. How long does it take to get an ETA?

The Home Office aims to process ETA applications within three working days. Some applications may take longer if additional checks are required.

9. Can I work in the UK with an ETA?

No. You may only carry out permitted activities as a visitor (e.g. attending meetings, giving unpaid speeches) or under the Creative Worker concession. Employment or long-term work is not permitted with an ETA.

10. Do I need an ETA to transit through the UK?

Yes. If you are a non-visa national transiting through the UK and would not normally require a visa, you must obtain an ETA before travel—even if you do not plan to leave the airport.

11. Can I travel from Ireland to the UK without an ETA?

If you are a non-visa national legally resident in Ireland, and you are crossing the land border into Northern Ireland, you do not need an ETA. However, if you are travelling to the UK by air or sea from outside the Common Travel Area, an ETA is required.

12. What happens if my ETA is refused?

If your ETA is refused, you cannot travel to the UK under the ETA scheme. However, you may still be eligible to apply for a Standard Visitor visa, Creative Worker visa, or Transit visa.

13. Can I reapply for an ETA after a refusal?

Possibly. If the refusal was due to incorrect information or documentation and your circumstances have changed, you may be able to reapply. However, if your refusal was based on suitability criteria (e.g. criminal history, immigration breaches), a reapplication is unlikely to succeed without a material change in circumstances.

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(<https://www.google.co.uk>

16. Can I appeal a refusal or cancellation of an ETA?

There is no formal right of appeal or administrative review against an ETA refusal or cancellation. However, you may still apply for a UK visa and, if appropriate, present evidence and legal arguments addressing the refusal.

Legal Advice on UK ETA Applications

Although the UK Electronic Travel Authorisation (ETA) process is designed to be quick and accessible, it is not without risk—particularly for individuals with complex personal or immigration histories. In many cases, early legal advice can make the difference between a straightforward approval and an unexpected refusal or cancellation.

At Richmond Chambers, our immigration barristers offer specialist guidance at every stage of the UK ETA process, including:

- Assessing eligibility based on your nationality, travel purpose, and immigration status;
- Advising on whether an ETA or a UK visa is the correct route for your circumstances;
- Reviewing ETA applications for accuracy and completeness, with particular attention to suitability questions;
- Assisting clients with previous visa refusals, criminal convictions, overstays, or complex histories to understand their risk of ETA refusal;
- Advising on the appropriate response to a refused or cancelled ETA, including preparation of a follow-on UK visa application;
- Supporting high-profile individuals, business travellers and repeat UK visitors to ensure continued compliance with immigration rules.

When to Seek Professional Advice

We strongly recommend seeking legal advice if:

- You have any prior criminal record, even for offences committed outside the UK;
- You have previously been refused a UK visa, or refused entry at the border;
- You have overstayed a previous period of leave in the UK or another country;
- You have used false documents or omitted information in prior applications;

- You have debts to the NHS or unpaid litigation costs owed to the Home Office;
- Your travel is time-sensitive (e.g. work engagements, medical treatment, business commitments) and you cannot afford delays or refusals;
- You have already had a UK ETA refused or cancelled, and wish to apply for a UK visa.

Every situation is unique, and a carefully prepared legal strategy can help protect your immigration record and travel plans.

Contact Richmond Chambers Immigration Barristers

Whether you are applying for a UK Electronic Travel Authorisation (ETA) for the first time, responding to a refusal or cancellation, or exploring alternative visa options, expert legal advice can help you make informed decisions and avoid unnecessary delays or refusals.

At Richmond Chambers, our team of specialist immigration barristers has extensive experience advising non-visa nationals, including business travellers, tourists, creatives, and those with complex immigration histories. We provide strategic, tailored advice on all aspects of the UK ETA scheme and associated visa routes.

We can assist you with determining your eligibility for a UK ETA, preparing and reviewing your ETA application, advising on potential risks or suitability concerns, responding to ETA refusals or cancellations, preparing UK visa applications if your ETA is not approved.

If you require legal advice or representation in connection with the UK Electronic Travel Authorisation scheme, contact our immigration barristers in London on +44 (0)203 617 9173 or complete our enquiry form below.

WE CAN ALSO ASSIST WITH

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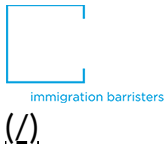


Applications for UK Visit Visas following a UK ETA Cancellation



WHAT CAN WE HELP YOU WITH?

To arrange an initial consultation meeting, call our immigration barristers on 0203 617 9173 or fill out the form below.



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LONDON OFFICE

Richmond Chambers LLP
Seven Henrietta Street
Covent Garden
London
WC2E 8PS

T / +44 0203 617 9173 (tel:+4402036179173)
E / info@richmondchambers.com (mailto:info@richmondchambers.com)

MONTREUX OFFICE

Avenue Des Alpes 80B
Montreux 1820
Switzerland

T / +41 21 588 07 70 (tel:+41215880770)
E / info@richmondchambers.ch (mailto:info@richmondchambers.ch)

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